

Chapter 63_2: Gift

Chu Qingqiu left halfway through the banquet. Ning Fuyi, seeing her expression was truly terrible, wanted to go check on her.

However, just as she reached the entrance of Jingshan Palace¹, she saw several immortal attendants clustered outside, whispering fearfully to each other. Upon seeing Ning Fuyi, they hurried forward: "Young Sect Master, thank goodness you've come! The Divine Venerable said she was going to punish Qiu Yi and drove us all out!"

"Now we can't hear anything either, and don't know what's happening. When the Divine Venerable gets cold-faced, it makes our hearts panic. If..."

"Miss Qiu Yi has always treated us well. She does all the personal tasks herself, never needing us to lift a finger. Seeing her punished now, we really can't bear it!"

"Young Sect Master, you're close with the Divine Venerable. Could you go in and take a look?"

Several immortal attendants spoke all at once, giving Ning Fuyi a splitting headache. She waved her hand, her phoenix eyes slightly narrowed: "Alright, alright, don't worry."

With that, she lifted her legs and entered. As soon as she stepped through the door, she heard the sound of wind howling, so she quickened her pace and reached the back courtyard in a few steps.

Just as she rounded the tree shadows, she heard a thud, accompanied by a woman's muffled groan. White light flashed in mid-air, and the White Bone weapon transformed into a white jade staff struck Qiu Yi's straight back, immediately bending her over.

Qiu Yi was tied up tightly with Flying Feather Rope². She bit down on her curved blade, biting so hard that her teeth left bloody marks. She only shed tears, not daring to make a sound.

"From the moment you entered Purple Mist Peak³, this venerable has warned you never to act rashly, to not do things purely on impulse without thinking. Sooner or later you'll die a violent death! Where did all my words go?" Chu Qingqiu said sternly. The white bone in mid-air struck down again, and Qiu Yi could no longer hold the curved blade in her mouth, crying out in pain.

That person's black hair fluttered, crowned with moonlight, cold as moonbeams. Yet when disciplining someone, she was quite terrifying. Ning Fuyi's heart tightened for a moment, and she stopped in place.

"Master, this disciple knows her error." Qiu Yi said through her tears, sobbing.

"You still blame this venerable for not letting you go out. If you could change even half of this temperament, how would this venerable need to control you!" Chu Qingqiu was about to strike again when she looked up and saw Ning Fuyi standing under the tree shadows. Her movement paused for a moment. "What are you doing standing there? Get out!"

"This disciple has come to receive punishment." Ning Fuyi spoke. She exhaled and walked to stand beside the bent-over Qiu Yi, standing straight. "Actually, I knew about this matter. It's just that I discovered it early and thought it wouldn't have any impact, so I only took away that feather without informing the Venerable."

Chu Qingqiu's beautiful face showed even deeper anger, her shoulders trembling with rage until she couldn't speak.

"This disciple accepts punishment." Ning Fuyi closed her eyes, thinking it was just a matter of a few strikes - she could take it.

However, after waiting a long time without feeling any pain, she heard a crashing noise behind her. She quickly opened her eyes to see dust filling the air and green leaves scattered on the ground. Chu Qingqiu had vented her anger on the tree behind them, actually striking the thick willow tree down with one blow.

Then the white jade staff was thrown hard to the ground, smashing a long strip-shaped crater in the floor tiles. Chu Qingqiu had already turned her back and strode away, showing the weight of her anger - even the summer night felt somewhat cold.

Ning Fuyi finally breathed a sigh of relief. Turning her head, she saw Qiu Yi collapsed on the ground, covering her heart and crying.

"The Venerable has already left. What are you still crying about?" Ning Fuyi wiped the dust from her face and said.

"I willingly accepted punishment for doing wrong, but I never thought Master would use White Bone⁴ to discipline me. White Bone is a divine weapon - one strike could shatter my internal organs. Having taken these few strikes, I'm surely not long for this world." Qiu Yi cried with tears and snot running down her face, as if she were about to die any moment.

"Though Master struck with a killing blow, this disciple absolutely doesn't blame her. It's just that from now on, there will be no one to serve Master and care for her in her old age!"

Seeing Qiu Yi's pale appearance, Ning Fuyi almost believed her. She quickly reached out to check her pulse, but found it strong and steady - nothing like someone with internal injuries.

Ning Fuyi was surprised and nimbly summoned immortal power to examine her back. Her originally furrowed brows gradually relaxed, and finally she laughed mockingly.

"What are you laughing at!" Qiu Yi said fiercely.

"Laughing at how you don't even know whether you're injured or not." Ning Fuyi dismissed the worry from her eyes, patted her skirt and stood up, though her mood was indescribable.

So Chu Qingqiu was this kind of person - tough-talking but soft-hearted. She appeared like a ruthless strict teacher, but when disciplining her disciple, she didn't forget to cast a barrier underneath, blocking ninety percent of White Bone's force.

Perhaps after all this punishment, Qiu Yi's back wouldn't even be red.

At this moment, Qiu Yi, who had been immersed in the sorrow of impending death, also realized what had happened. She made a surprised sound and sprang up like a carp, feeling herself all over with a face full of amazement.

"Want to go see your master?" Ning Fuyi said nothing more, only asking lightly.

Qiu Yi nodded.

The two crept to the bottom of the pavilion. Chu Qingqiu hadn't returned to her room but was staying in the first-floor tea room, sitting properly in a grand chair with her back to the door, a cup of cooling tea for reducing internal heat in front of her, saying nothing.

Ning Fuyi and Qiu Yi tiptoed to the doorway, but two teacups came flying toward them. Qiu Yi quickly dodged sideways, while Ning Fuyi raised her hand, caught the teacup, and set it down with a calm expression.

"Master..." Qiu Yi shuffled forward to her side, pleading in her words. "It's all this disciple's fault. This disciple swears on her dignity that she will never make this mistake again."

Chu Qingqiu still didn't speak. Qiu Yi was at a loss and returned to the doorway, starting to push Ning Fuyi: "Master won't listen to me. You go, you go."

Ning Fuyi was pushed to Chu Qingqiu's side. Looking down, she saw the woman sitting properly, hands in her lap rolling a string of sandalwood prayer beads. The bean-sized lamplight fell on the other side of her face, leaving the side facing Ning Fuyi in shadow.

"Get out. Don't disturb me." Chu Qingqiu said coldly.

Ning Fuyi really didn't know how to coax people, but she was indeed at fault in this matter. Finding herself in difficulty, she thought for a long time before saying: "Venerable, your health isn't good. Don't anger yourself into illness."

These words were really tasteless. Hearing them, Chu Qingqiu became even more silent, even her fingertips beginning to clench, showing signs of throwing them both out.

Finally, Ning Fuyi had no choice but to throw caution to the wind and managed to squeeze out: "Venerable, shall I perform a magic trick for you?"

This wasn't her idea, but a method Ning Changfeng occasionally used to coax her when she cried and made a fuss - conjuring a candy or a pastry would make her crying quieter.

She pulled out a bell from somewhere and began shaking it left and right, seriously muttering something. Her no-longer-so-slender body spun in circles toward Chu Qingqiu, her skirt hem creating petal-like ripples at her feet.

Actually, Ning Fuyi had now grown to be eighty percent similar to her previous life, but lacking those two teardrop moles, she also lacked the sinister aura and looked much more approachable.

Chu Qingqiu seemed attracted by her comical movements, finally no longer staring intently at the teacup in front of her, but looking up at her instead.

Seeing this method worked, Qiu Yi quickly stepped forward to join in, also learning from Ning Fuyi to dance around in circles.

Chu Qingqiu didn't know whether to be angry or amused, or perhaps she was angry enough to laugh. Her tense expression relaxed somewhat: "Are you done fooling around? If you're done, get out."

Ning Fuyi couldn't just spin in circles - she hadn't performed the magic trick yet. She thought about what she could conjure up, then suddenly had an inspiration. She flipped her wrist to hide the bell in her palm, and when she opened it in front of Chu Qingqiu, the thing in her palm had changed to a jade bracelet carved with gardenia flowers.

Chu Qingqiu's heartstrings moved, her eyelashes trembling involuntarily. An irrepressible joy welled up in her heart, but she immediately bit down hard on the soft flesh in her mouth, restraining thoughts that couldn't be seen by others.

"What is this?" she said lightly.

"Conjured by magic." Ning Fuyi's eyes were deep as she extended the bracelet toward Chu Qingqiu's face. "The Venerable seems to like gardenia flowers⁵."

Chu Qingqiu didn't speak for a long time. Finally, she reached out and took the pleasing jade-colored bracelet, holding it in her palm as if nothing had happened.

"Alright, go now."

Footnotes:

¹ **Jingshan Palace (静山宫)** - Chu Qingqiu's residence, literally "Quiet Mountain Palace"

² **Flying Feather Rope (飞羽索)** - A magical binding tool made from feathers that can transform and restrain people

³ **Purple Mist Peak (紫霞峰)** - The mountain peak where Chu Qingqiu's residence is located

⁴ **White Bone (白骨)** - Chu Qingqiu's divine weapon that can transform into various forms, including a white jade staff

⁵ **Gardenia flowers (梔子花)** - White, fragrant flowers that symbolize purity, peace, and secret love in Chinese culture